

JET, SET... An F-35 tears into the Bengaluru sky at Aero India 2023

AREAS OF COOPERATION

- India-US initiative on Critical and Emerging Technologies (iCET) aims for strategic tech partnership, defence industrial cooperation
- India-US mulling joint production of variant of M777 howitzer
- US in final stages of selling Predator-B armed drones to India, will sell 18 armed MQ-9 Predator drones
- India-US to co-develop air-launched UAVs, a $22 million project

putting it on par with its closest allies.

Now, Washington is thinking differently about critical technology transfer. The border stand-off between India and China along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) has lent it urgency, since both India and the US have a common adversary in Beijing, and Washington wants to boost New Delhi's firepower. The rapidly changing geopolitical scenario in the wake of the Ukraine conflict has also influenced its thinking.

The two countries have had a defence trade of over $20 billion in the past decade and a half, including procurement of C-130J and C-17 transport aircraft, P-81 maritime patrol aircraft, Harpoon missiles, Apache, Chinook and MH-60R helicopters and M777 howitzers. India is also procuring F404 – GE IN20 engines for its indigenous Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) Tejas and has selected the GE – F414 INS6 for the Mark II version of Tejas and the fifth generation Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA). Both aircraft are under development.

'STRATEGIC TECHNOLOGY PARTNERSHIP'

During his Washington visit in early February, National Security Advisor Ajit Doval had a discussion with his US counterpart Jake Sullivan on cutting-edge technologies. They co-chaired the inaugural meeting of the initiative on Critical and Emerging Technologies (iCET). A White House factsheet said that iCET aimed to "elevate and expand our strategic technology partnership and defence industrial cooperation". The iCET, it said, aims to position the nations as "trusted technology partners", deepen defence ties with a focus on co-production and co-development, and institutionalise a standing mechanism to overcome regulatory barriers and export controls. Under the iCET, a new 'innovation bridge' will be created to connect defence start-ups on both sides.

India and the US are exploring the possibility of jointly developing a variant of the M777 ultra lightweight howitzer with an extended range. In addition, the Pentagon is in the final stages of selling Predator-B armed drones to India. If the deal goes through, India will be the first country outside the NATO alliance to get such a weapon. India is expected to buy 18 armed MQ-9 Predator drones (six each for the different wings of the armed forces). The deal may be announced during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the US in June.

Moreover, last year, the US signed an agreement with India to co-develop air-launched Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs), as an inaugural co-development project under the US-India Defense Technology and Trade Initiative (DTTI). The project is valued at over $22 million and marks the largest-ever defence research, development, test and evaluation collaboration between the two nations.

Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Jeff Abramson, a senior fellow at the US-based Arms Control Association, said that for over two decades, America has sought to increase defence exports to India. "The latest developments on this front should be seen as part of that decades-long trend. Clearly, this is an attempt to pull